

Do You Know Your Cholesterol Levels?

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What Is Cholesterol?

Cholesterol is a waxy, fat-like substance found in your body. Your body makes all the cholesterol you need to be healthy on its own. But when you eat foods high in saturated fat, trans fat, and cholesterol, your body can make too much. Over time, this extra cholesterol can clog your arteries, increasing your chances of having a heart attack or stroke.

Good Cholesterol and Bad Cholesterol

HDL is “good cholesterol.” It helps clean fat and cholesterol from your blood vessels. Remember the H in HDL for Healthy — the higher it is, the better.

LDL is “bad cholesterol.” It carries cholesterol to your blood vessels, clogging them like rust in a pipe. Remember the L in LDL for Lousy — the lower it is, the better.

The blood test that measures these levels is called a lipid profile, done at a doctor's office. If you're 20 or older, get your cholesterol checked at least every 5 years — more often if your levels are high.

What Your Numbers Mean

- Total cholesterol — less than 200 mg/dL is ideal; 200 to 239 mg/dL is borderline high; 240 mg/dL or more is high.
- LDL (bad) cholesterol — keep it low; less than 100 mg/dL is ideal.
- HDL (good) cholesterol — the higher the better; keep it at 40 mg/dL or more.
- Triglycerides — another type of fat in the blood; a healthy level is less than 150 mg/dL. High triglycerides raise your risk for heart disease.

The Metabolic Syndrome

The metabolic syndrome is a group of factors that increase your chances of developing heart disease or stroke, and also raises your risk for diabetes. Having three or more of the following means you have the metabolic syndrome:

- A high waist measurement — more than 35 inches for women, or more than 40 inches for men
- A triglyceride level of 150 mg/dL or more
- A low HDL (good) cholesterol level — less than 50 mg/dL for women, or less than 40 mg/dL for men
- Blood pressure of 130/85 or more
- A high fasting blood sugar of 100 mg/dL or more

If you have three or more of these factors, talk to your doctor about the metabolic syndrome.

Lowering Your Cholesterol

A few key steps can help lower and control blood cholesterol:

- Cut back on foods high in saturated fat and trans fat — the two fats that raise blood cholesterol the most. Saturated fat is found in high-fat meat, cheese, milk, and butter; trans fat is found in vegetable shortening, stick margarine, fried foods, and many baked goods like cookies and pastries.
- Eat more fat-free milk, cheese, and yogurt; fruits, vegetables, and whole grains; fish; skinless turkey and chicken; lean cuts of meat; and beans and lentils.
- Cut back on fatty cuts of meat, sausage and hot dogs, organ meats, and butter or stick margarine; limit egg yolks to no more than four a week.
- Read food labels to compare saturated fat, trans fat, and cholesterol content between similar foods before choosing.
- Do 30 to 60 minutes of moderate physical activity on most days.
- Aim for a healthy weight, and lose weight if you're overweight.

To help control triglycerides specifically: control your weight, stay physically active, quit smoking, limit foods and drinks high in sugar, and limit alcohol.

A Simple Family Action Plan

- Get your cholesterol level checked.
- Talk to your doctor about what your numbers mean.
- Read food labels to choose foods lower in saturated fat, trans fat, cholesterol, and calories.
- Bake, broil, or grill foods instead of frying them.
- Eat more fruits, vegetables, and whole grains.
- Drink water or sugar-free beverages instead of regular soda.
- Maintain a healthy weight, or work toward one.
- Do 30 to 60 minutes of moderate physical activity on most days.

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